CROSS-BORDER NOTES

On August 7, a Uzbek bank went on state television and announced it is converting to Islamic finance.

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Sun Choi

MKBANK said it is reforming its banking system, right alongside promotions for domestic retail products. That pairing is the tell.

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Banks don't reframe their operating model for a retail campaign. They do it when the regulator has signaled where capital is allowed to come from next.

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Gulf capital lands where the plumbing already exists. No sukuk desk, no murabaha structuring, no Islamic window: no serious GCC allocation.

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Regulatory intent precedes capital. If Tashkent normalizes Islamic finance at the bank level, sovereign and quasi-sovereign issuance tends to follow.

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> **Whoever converts first sets the terms for the capital that follows. Treat this like a central bank circular, not a press release.**

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